Sync conflicts and duplicate files

Article KB0010074 | Owner: Messaging & Collaboration | Subcategory: OneDrive / SharePoint sync | Applies to: Windows 11 (22H2/23H2/24H2) on Dell Latitude, Lenovo ThinkPad, HP EliteBook, macOS 14/15 on MacBook Pro/Air, OneDrive sync client (version 23.x or later), SharePoint Online document libraries synced via OneDrive

Summary

OneDrive sync conflicts appear when the client cannot reconcile changes between the local folder and the cloud, often creating files with "(conflict copy)" or duplicate names. This article explains the common causes, provides a self-help troubleshooting flow for end-users, and outlines the steps the Messaging & Collaboration service desk follows to restore sync and close the ticket.

Symptoms

- OneDrive icon shows a red "x" or "Processing changes" status
- Notification: "We're having trouble syncing?-?see details for more information"
- File Explorer shows files appended with " (conflict copy)" or " - Copy"
- Error dialog: "The file name contains invalid characters"
- OneDrive reports storage quota exceeded or path too long (>260 characters)

Common causes

- File or folder names containing prohibited characters \ / : * ? " < > |
- Files locked by another application or open with exclusive access
- Path length exceeding Windows MAX_PATH limit (260 characters)
- OneDrive storage quota reached (50?GB mailbox + online archive does not apply; OneDrive personal limit varies)
- Outdated OneDrive client missing recent sync fixes
- Simultaneous edits causing conflicting versions
- Case-insensitive filesystem creating duplicate names when syncing from macOS/Linux

Understanding sync conflicts and duplicate files

When the OneDrive sync client detects that the same file has been changed both locally and in the cloud, it cannot decide which version to keep. It therefore saves the local version with a suffix such as " (conflict copy)" and leaves the cloud version untouched. Similar behavior occurs when a file name contains characters that are not allowed on the destination filesystem, or when the sync path exceeds the maximum allowed length. The result is a stalled sync state, duplicate files, and sometimes the OneDrive icon showing an error.

Self-help troubleshooting steps

Follow these steps to resolve most sync conflict and duplicate file issues before contacting the service desk. Each step builds on the previous one; stop as soon as sync resumes normally.

1. Close any open Office or other files that might be locked in the OneDrive folder.
2. Rename files or folders that contain illegal characters (\ / : * ? " < > |) or are excessively long; keep names under 250 characters to stay safely below the path limit.
3. Pause OneDrive sync (right-click the OneDrive tray icon -> Pause syncing -> 2 hours), then resume to force a re-evaluation of pending changes.
4. If the problem persists, reset the OneDrive client: right-click the tray icon -> Settings -> Account -> Unlink this PC, then sign back in with your corporate credentials.
5. After relinking, check the OneDrive activity center for any remaining conflict files; delete or rename them as needed, then allow sync to complete.
6. Verify that the OneDrive status shows a green check-mark and that files appear correctly in both File Explorer and SharePoint Online.

Service-desk agent procedure

When a user contacts the Service Desk with a sync-conflict ticket, use the following workflow to diagnose and remediate the issue efficiently. Document each action in the ticket.

1. Confirm the user's device, OS version, and OneDrive client version (ask them to run %localappdata%\Microsoft\OneDrive\OneDrive.exe /version).
2. Guide the user through steps 1-3 of the self-help flow (close locked files, rename illegal characters, pause/resume sync). If sync resumes, close the ticket with verification notes.
3. If the issue remains, have the user unlink and relink OneDrive (step?4). Capture any error messages shown during the unlink/relink process.
4. After relinking, ask the user to check for conflict files in the OneDrive folder and either delete them or move them outside the sync directory.
5. Confirm that the OneDrive status is healthy and that the SharePoint library shows no sync errors. Close the ticket with a summary of the root cause and resolution.

Verification and closure

Before closing the ticket, ensure the user can verify that sync is functioning correctly. Provide clear confirmation steps and remind the user of preventive practices to avoid future conflicts.

Prevention tips

Encourage users to avoid special characters in file names, keep folder paths reasonably short, and close files before leaving them unattended. Regularly updating the OneDrive client via Company Portal also reduces the likelihood of sync bugs.

When to escalate

If the user continues to experience sync failures after completing the service-desk procedure (unlink/relink, conflict-file cleanup, and client version check), escalate to the Messaging & Collaboration senior team. Include in the escalation: device hostname, OneDrive client version, exact error messages, screenshots of the OneDrive activity center, and a list of any remaining conflict files. Do not escalate to Identity & Access Management unless the root cause is determined to be a permission or conditional-access issue blocking access to the SharePoint site.

Keywords: OneDrive sync conflict, duplicate files, SharePoint library not syncing, OneDrive not syncing, invalid file name, path too long, OneDrive reset, unlink OneDrive, relink OneDrive, sync paused, processing changes, conflict copy